

From Wild West to Well-Run:

An Introduction to Power BI Governance



MsBelindaAllen





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From Wild West to Well-Run: An Introduction to Power BI Governance

Power BI makes it easy to build and share insights—but without the right governance, it can quickly turn into a “wild west” of duplicate reports, inconsistent data, and unclear ownership. So how do you bring order without slowing innovation?

In this session, we'll break down what Power BI governance really means and how to implement it in a practical, approachable way. You'll learn how to strike the right balance between control and flexibility while empowering your users to build with confidence.

We'll walk through the core components of a successful governance strategy—including workspace organization, data ownership, security, and lifecycle management—along with real-world examples of what works (and what doesn't). Whether you're just getting started or trying to clean up an existing environment, this session will give you actionable steps to move forward.

If you're responsible for scaling Power BI across your organization, this is your starting point for building a trusted, secure, and well-managed analytics environment.

Why This Matters Now:

- Fabric is accelerating data sprawl
- AI depends on trusted, governed data
- Self-service BI without governance = confusion, not insight

From Alcolu, SC

- I lived the longest in New York City

In Technology

- Change & Enablement Leader
- Started in tech in 1991
- Microsoft Partner since 2001

Microsoft MVP

- 14 years / 5 years GP and 9 years Power BI (and now Fabric)

Microsoft MCT

- 15 years (with a hiatus in the middle)

Co-Authored 2 books

- BI and Dynamics GP

I love learning

- Technology, Wood Turning, Cooking

I love hobbies

- Knitting/crocheting, making jewelry, reiki

01 Welcome & Why Governance Matters More Than Ever

02 Recognizing the "Wild West" Symptoms

03 What Power BI Governance Really Is (and Isn't)

04 The 6 Pillars of Power BI Governance

05 Governance in Action: Real-World Examples

06 Building Your Governance Roadmap

07 Key Takeaways & Q&A

Governance is not about controlling people — it's about creating trust.



Governance enables scale

As self-service analytics grows, governance prevents chaos and builds confidence across the org.



Fabric accelerates innovation AND risk

Microsoft Fabric expands capabilities fast. Without governance, complexity spirals out of control.



AI is only as good as your data

AI-generated insights are unreliable without governed, certified, trustworthy data sources.



Governance builds trust

When users can trust the data they see, they make better decisions — and use Power BI more.



WHY GOVERNANCE MATTERS MORE THAN EVER

★ Governance is not about controlling people — it's about **creating trust**. ★

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1 GOVERNANCE ENABLES SCALE



We want to help everyone with data!

Governance is the sturdy bridge and strong rails that let us grow safely.

As self-service analytics grows, governance prevents chaos and builds confidence across the org.

ANALYTICS TEAM

TRUST

RULES & GUARDRAILS

2 FABRIC ACCELERATES INNOVATION AND RISK



Microsoft Fabric is super fast!

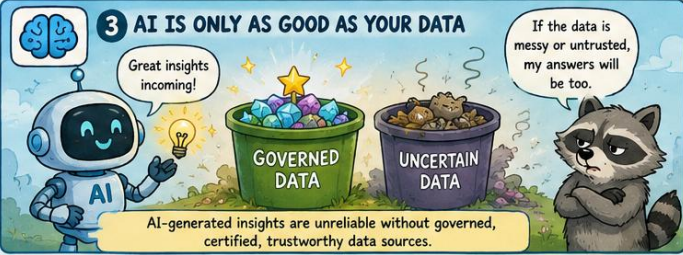
Whoa! Without governance, we'll get lost in complexity!

COMPLEXITY MAP

CHAOS

Microsoft Fabric expands capabilities fast. Without governance, complexity spirals out of control.

3 AI IS ONLY AS GOOD AS YOUR DATA



Great insights incoming!

If the data is messy or untrusted, my answers will be too.

AI-generated insights are unreliable without governed, certified, trustworthy data sources.

AI

GOVERNED DATA

UNCERTAIN DATA

4 GOVERNANCE BUILDS TRUST



I trust this data!

Better decisions, better outcomes!

More Power BI. More impact!

When users can trust the data they see, they make better decisions — and use Power BI more.

POWER BI



Governance isn't the brakes — it's the seatbelt. It keeps us safe so we can **go farther, together!**

GOVERNANCE = FREEDOM TO DO GREAT WORK

RECIPE FOR SUCCESS

- ✓ Enable scale
- ✓ Accelerate innovation (and manage risk)
- ✓ Trust your data
- ✓ Empower better decisions

ANALYTICS TEAM

How many Sales reports does your organization have?



Multiple versions of the same report



Security & compliance concerns



Conflicting metrics across departments



Report sprawl across workspaces



Unclear report ownership



Nobody knows which report to trust



Orphaned datasets nobody maintains

Most organizations don't realize they have a governance problem until trust is lost.



WHY GOVERNANCE MATTERS FOR SUCCESS

Too many reports. Not enough **trust**. Sound familiar?

This is what happens when reports run wild and governance is missing!

! MULTIPLE VERSIONS OF THE SAME REPORT

Which one is real?!

Q1 Sales Report v1
Q1 Sales Report_FINAL
Q1 Sales Report v3
Q1 FINAL (Really Final)
Q1 Sales Report_v2

Q1 SALES REPORT ?

! CONFLICTING METRICS ACROSS DEPARTMENTS

New customers this month: 120!
No, it's 98!

SALES New Customers 120
MARKETING New Customers 98

Different numbers. Different stories. Nobody knows what's true.

! UNCLEAR REPORT OWNERSHIP

So... who owns this report?
Hmm... not me!
I thought you did...

SALES REPORT ???

! ORPHANED DATASETS NOBODY MAINTAINS

Nobody loves me...

OLD DATASET (Who knows what this is?)

! SECURITY & COMPLIANCE CONCERNS

Ooo... juicy data!

Without governance, we're taking big risks!

SENSITIVE DATA UNPROTECTED

! REPORT SPRAWL ACROSS WORKSPACES

It's everywhere! I can't find anything!

! NOBODY KNOWS WHICH REPORT TO TRUST

Every report says something different... What do I believe?

REPORT A
REPORT B
REPORT C
REPORT... ZZZ?

★ THE FIX: GOVERNANCE BUILDS TRUST. TRUST DRIVES SUCCESS! ★

With good governance, we all win!

ONE SOURCE OF TRUTH
CLEAR OWNERSHIP & RESPONSIBILITY
CLEAN & MAINTAINED DATA
SECURE & COMPLIANT
FIND WHAT YOU NEED, WHERE YOU NEED IT
DECISIONS YOU CAN COUNT ON

TRUSTED REPORT

SUCCESS!

Most organizations don't realize they have a governance problem until trust is lost. Don't wait. Govern. Trust. Succeed.

What Power BI Governance Really Is (and Isn't)

✓ Governance IS...

- ✓ Defining clear ownership
- ✓ Establishing data standards
- ✓ Managing organizational risk
- ✓ Ensuring data trust
- ✓ Enabling self-service safely

✗ Governance IS NOT...

- ✗ Restricting innovation
- ✗ Central IT controlling everything
- ✗ Excessive approval processes
- ✗ Unnecessary bureaucracy
- ✗ A one-time project — it's ongoing

Good governance creates freedom within guardrails.

What Power BI Governance Really Is (and Isn't)

✗ GOVERNANCE IS NOT... ✗

1 RESTRICTING INNOVATION ✗



I have an idea that could change everything!

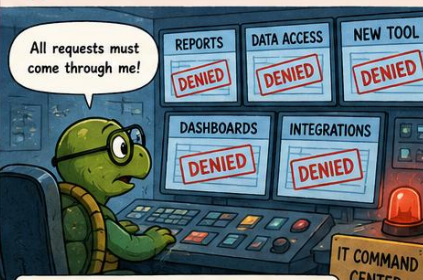
Nope. Too risky. Stick to the same old way.

NEW IDEA!

RULES NO EXPERIMENTS ALLOWED.

★ Good governance clears the path for safe, smart innovation.

2 CENTRAL IT CONTROLLING EVERYTHING ✗



All requests must come through me!

REPORTS DENIED

DATA ACCESS DENIED

NEW TOOL DENIED

DASHBOARDS DENIED

INTEGRATIONS DENIED

IT COMMAND CENTER

★ Good governance empowers teams with the right access and guardrails.

3 EXCESSIVE APPROVAL PROCESSES ✗



I just need a simple report...

STEP 4 COMMITTEE

STEP 3 ESCALATE

STEP 5 FINANCE

STEP 5 LEGAL

STEP 7? APPROVED?

Maybe... one day.

★ Good governance streamlines processes, not slows people down.

4 UNNECESSARY BUREAUCRACY ✗



I need ONE number, but first...

FORM 17-B

- ✓ FORM A
- ✓ FORM B
- ✓ FORM C
- ✓ FORM D
- ✓ FORM E
- ✓ FORM F
- ✓ FORM G
- ✓ FORM H

...AND MORE!

★ Good governance keeps it simple, clear, and useful.

5 A ONE-TIME PROJECT — IT'S ONGOING ✗



DAY 1: LAUNCH!

GOVERNANCE INITIATIVE

DAY 180...

NO UPDATES NO REVIEWS NO OWNERS

★ Good governance is a journey — we adapt, improve, and grow.

INSTEAD, GOOD GOVERNANCE IS...



Enables innovation

Empowers teams

Builds trust

Manages risk

Drives better decisions

TRUST + CLARITY + VALUE

♥ Good governance isn't about saying NO — it's about saying YES to what matters. ♥

What Power BI Governance Really Is (and Isn't)



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Where does your organization fall today?

No standards. Reports created freely, no ownership, no documentation.

Basic rules exist. Some workspace structure. IT involved reactively.

Defined policies. Certified datasets. Ownership assigned and enforced.

Automated monitoring. Proactive governance. Culture of data trust.

1

Ad Hoc

2

Controlled

3

3

Managed

4

Optimized

Maturity Journey →

04

The 6 Pillars of Power BI Governance

Your core framework for building a governed, trusted analytics environment.

Governance succeeds when all six pillars work together.

The 6 Pillars of Power BI Governance

1



Ownership & Accountability

Data Owners · Report Owners
Workspace Owners

2



Workspace Strategy

Dept vs. Project Workspaces
Dev / Test / Prod · Naming

3



Data Governance

Certified Datasets · Endorsed
Single Source of Truth

4



Security & Access

Row-Level Security (RLS)
Workspace Roles · Sharing

5



Lifecycle Management

Development · Deployment
Retirement of content

6



Monitoring & Adoption

Usage Metrics · Audit Logs
Adoption Tracking

Data Owner

- Owns the semantic model / dataset
- Ensures data quality and accuracy
- Approves certification requests
- Communicates changes to consumers

Report Owner

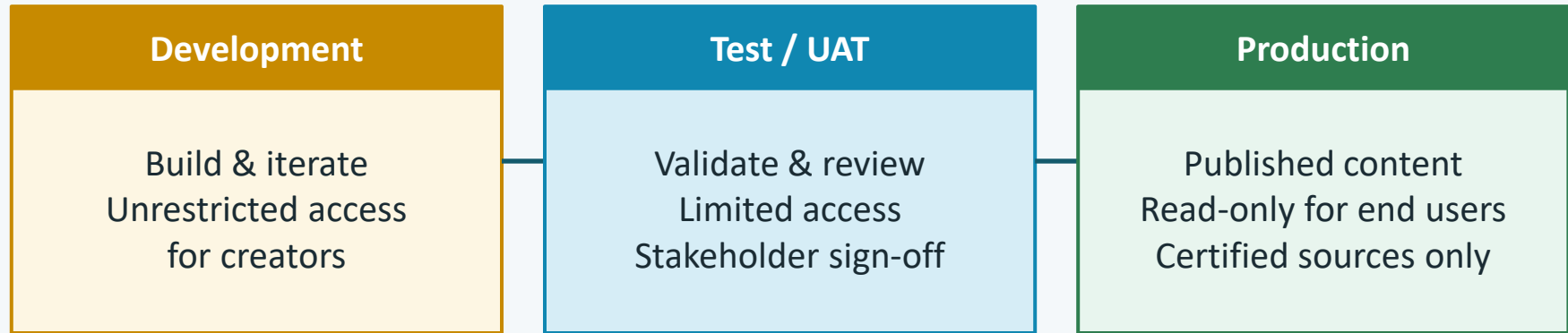
- Responsible for report accuracy
- Manages report lifecycle
- Communicates updates to stakeholders
- Requests data changes from Data Owner

Workspace Owner

- Manages workspace membership & roles
- Ensures naming standards are followed
- Oversees workspace lifecycle
- Coordinates with IT on permissions

Pro tip: Document every owner in a Governance Register — a simple spreadsheet works fine to start.

Pillar 2: Workspace Strategy



Workspace Naming Standards

[Dept] - [Team] - DEV → Finance-FP&A-DEV

[Dept] - [Team] - TEST → Finance-FP&A-TEST

[Dept] - [Team] - PROD → Finance-FP&A-PROD

[Project] - [Name] - DEV → Project-Reorg2025-DEV

3 Data Governance

- Certified datasets = gold standard
- Endorsed = recommended but not official
- One semantic model per domain
- Clear lineage & documentation

4 Security & Access

- Row-Level Security (RLS) for data filtering
- Workspace roles: Admin, Member, Contributor, Viewer
- Avoid sharing individual reports externally
- External sharing requires governance policy

5 Lifecycle Management

- Dev → Test → Prod deployment pipeline
- Retirement process for stale reports
- Change management notifications
- Deployment pipelines in Fabric

6 Monitoring & Adoption

- Usage metrics per workspace & report
- Audit logs for access & export tracking
- Identify unused / orphaned content
- Track adoption trends over time

✗ BEFORE Governance

- ✗ 14 versions of "Sales Report" across 9 workspaces
- ✗ Each team calculated revenue differently
- ✗ Leadership received conflicting numbers in board meetings
- ✗ No one knew which report was authoritative
- ✗ Hours spent reconciling data every month-end

✓ AFTER Governance

- ✓ One certified Sales semantic model owned by Finance
- ✓ Shared dataset used by all departments
- ✓ Single source of truth for all revenue figures
- ✓ Report retired or consolidated into certified version
- ✓ Month-end close time reduced by 6 hours

Lesson: Governance failures are people & process issues — not technology issues.

Example #1 — Security Gone Wrong

Problem

A report containing employee salaries was shared as a public link. Anyone with the link could view sensitive HR data.

Root Cause

No workspace sharing policy. No RLS configured. Report shared to entire organization by mistake.

Solution

Implemented RLS by department. Restricted external sharing. Created data classification policy (Public / Internal / Confidential).

Example #2 — Fabric Expansion Without Guardrails

Scenario

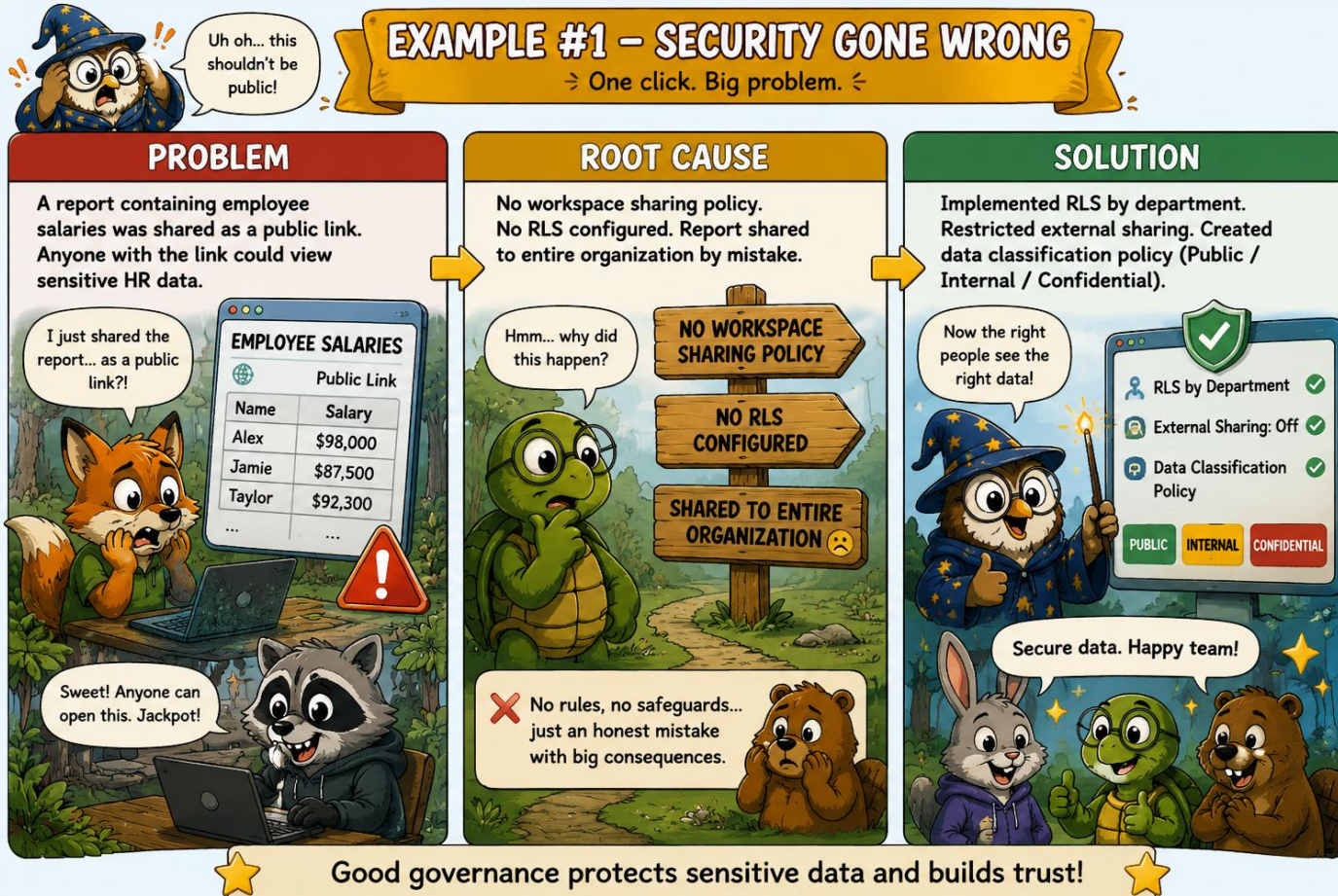
After Fabric launch, teams created lakehouses, pipelines, and notebooks freely. No naming standards, no ownership, rapid duplication.

Impact

Storage costs ballooned. Duplicate data across lakehouses. No data lineage. IT couldn't identify who owned what.

Governance

Created a Fabric Governance Framework: capacity governance, workspace templates, lakehouse naming standards, and a Fabric Center of Excellence.





What happened next?

EXAMPLE #2 – FABRIC EXPANSION WITHOUT GUARDRAILS

Grow fast without guardrails... and chaos grows faster!

SCENARIO

After Fabric launch, teams created lakehouses, pipelines, and notebooks freely. No naming standards, no ownership, rapid duplication.



IMPACT

Storage costs ballooned. Duplicate data across lakehouses. No data lineage. IT couldn't identify who owned what.



GOVERNANCE

Created a Fabric Governance Framework: capacity governance, workspace templates, lakehouse naming standards, and a Fabric Center of Excellence.



Good governance brings order, saves money, and helps everyone build with confidence!



A Very Common Power BI Scenario (Composite Example)



Example: A Very Common Power BI Scenario (Composite Example)

This is not one company—it's a scenario many organizations experience.

What Happened

1. HR publishes a salary report.
2. Report is shared using a broad audience group.
3. Row-Level Security (RLS) is not configured.
4. Someone forwards the link.

Impact

- 👤 Employees see salary information they should never access.
- 👤 HR, Legal, and IT become involved.

Root Cause

- ✗ No sharing policy.
- ✗ No data classification.
- ✗ No governance review process.

Governance Fix

- ✓ RLS by department.
- ✓ Sensitivity labels.
- ✓ Workspace ownership.
- ✓ Certified semantic models.

Day 30

Quick Wins & Inventory

- Inventory all workspaces
- Identify report and dataset owners
- Document critical / trusted reports
- Assess current security settings

Day 60

Standards & Structure

- Define workspace naming standards
- Establish workspace strategy (Dev/Test/Prod)
- Identify datasets for certification
- Create a governance charter

Day 90

Governance in Motion

- Form a Governance Committee
- Implement usage monitoring
- Begin certification process
- Publish governance documentation

People → Process → Technology (not the other way around)

Level	State of governance
100: Initial	• Due to a lack of governance planning, the good data management and informal governance practices that are occurring are overly reliant on judgment and experience level of individuals. • There's a significant reliance on undocumented tribal knowledge.
200: Repeatable	• Some areas of the organization have made a purposeful effort to standardize, improve, and document their data management and governance practices. • An initial governance approach exists. Incremental progress is being made.
300: Defined	• A complete governance strategy with focus, objectives, and priorities is enacted and broadly communicated. • Specific governance guidelines and policies are implemented for the top few priorities (pain points or opportunities). They're actively and consistently followed by users. • Roles and responsibilities are clearly defined and documented.
400: Capable	• All Fabric governance priorities align with organizational goals and business objectives. Goals are reassessed regularly. • Processes exist to customize policies for decentralized business units, or to handle valid exceptions to standard governance policies. • It's clear where Fabric fits into the overall data and BI strategy for the organization. • Fabric activity log and API data is actively analyzed to monitor and audit Fabric activities. Proactive action is taken based on the data.
500: Efficient	• Regular reviews of KPIs or OKRs evaluate measurable governance goals. Iterative, continual progress is a priority. • Agility and implementing continual improvements from lessons learned (including scaling out methods that work) are top priorities for the COE. • Fabric activity log and API data is actively used to inform and improve adoption and governance efforts.

★ 5 LEVELS OF GOVERNANCE MATURITY ★

From “Where’s the data?” to “We’re data-smart!”



★ Every step forward builds a stronger, smarter, more data-driven organization! ❤️ ★

Key Takeaways

- 01 Governance enables self-service analytics — it doesn't restrict it.
- 02 Trusted data is the foundation of AI and analytics success.
- 03 Start with ownership and standards before implementing tools.

*"The goal isn't to govern every report
— it's to create an environment where users can confidently find, trust, and use data."*

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<https://forms.cloud.microsoft/r/PMeb2Bp9Tv>





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Questions & Discussion

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